GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

Ministry of External Affairs

Strengthening India's Global Partnerships

SHRI NARENDRA MODI

HONORABLE PRIME MINISTER, INDIA



MESSAGE

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HONORABLE MINISTER,
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MESSAGE

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MESSAGE

India's growing role on the global stage reflects its expanding economic strength, strategic partnerships, diplomatic leadership, and commitment to international cooperation. The Ministry of External Affairs plays a vital role in advancing India's foreign policy objectives, strengthening bilateral and multilateral relations, promoting economic diplomacy, facilitating international trade and investment, and enhancing global engagement.

The Chamber of Commerce and Industries of India (CCI India) recognizes the increasing importance of economic diplomacy in creating new opportunities for trade, investment, technology transfer, innovation, education, and international business collaboration. Through policy advocacy, global business engagement, investment promotion, trade facilitation, and institutional partnerships, CCI India remains committed to supporting the Ministry's efforts in strengthening India's international economic presence.

This Knowledge Paper provides comprehensive insights into the Ministry's strategic priorities, diplomatic initiatives, international partnerships, policy framework, and emerging opportunities for cross-border collaboration. It highlights avenues for enhancing trade relations, investment flows, startup cooperation, innovation partnerships, skill exchange, global value chains, and international institutional engagement.

The publication is intended to serve policymakers, diplomats, industry leaders, investors, exporters, entrepreneurs, academic institutions, international organizations, and development partners seeking to contribute to India's global engagement. By fostering informed dialogue and strategic collaboration, it aims to strengthen India's economic diplomacy and international competitiveness.

As India continues to strengthen its position as a responsible global partner, collaboration between government, industry, and international stakeholders will become increasingly important. CCI India remains committed to supporting the Ministry of External Affairs in advancing India's vision of global cooperation, economic prosperity, and sustainable development.

Munindra Kumar
Director General
CCI India

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PREFACE

India's emergence as a global power in the 21st century is inextricably linked to the quality, depth, and strategic vision of its external engagement. At the heart of this transformation stands the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) the constitutional custodian of India's diplomatic identity, the architect of its international relationships, and the principal executor of its foreign policy across more than 200 diplomatic missions worldwide. As India aspires to become the world's third-largest economy by 2030 and fulfil its Viksit Bharat 2047 vision, the MEA's role has expanded beyond traditional diplomacy into the domains of economic statecraft, diaspora governance, climate multilateralism, and technology diplomacy.

This Knowledge Paper has been prepared by CCI India Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India as a strategic advisory document to facilitate a structured, high-value collaboration between India's industry ecosystem and the Ministry of External Affairs. It is grounded in publicly available government reports, official MEA publications, Union Budget documents, parliamentary committee records, international institutional data, and authoritative policy research.

The central thesis of this paper is that the MEA's ambitious foreign policy agenda spanning Neighbourhood First, Act East, G20 and BRICS leadership, Global South advocacy, diaspora diplomacy, and economic multilateralism cannot be fully realized without robust industry participation. CCI India, with its national network, policy advocacy capabilities, sectoral expertise, investor connectivity, and global institutional linkages, is uniquely positioned to serve as the MEA's industry-side implementation partner across these priority domains.

This paper is intended for: Union Ministers and Secretaries to the Government of India, senior MEA officials and Indian Foreign Service officers, NITI Aayog and Planning bodies, industry leaders and investors seeking global market access, international development agencies, and multilateral institutions. It is designed to serve as a conversation-starter for a structured, outcome-oriented engagement between CCI India and the MEA in the service of India's national interest.

CHAMBER OF COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY OF INDIA (CCI INDIA)

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About CCI India

CCI India (The Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India) is a premier national business chamber dedicated to fostering economic growth, industry development, entrepreneurship, innovation, and investment promotion across India. As the voice of Indian business and industry, CCI India serves as a bridge between government, industry, startups, academia, investors, and civil society, facilitating meaningful collaboration for nation-building and sustainable development.

Through policy advocacy, business facilitation, research, stakeholder engagement, capacity building, and strategic partnerships, CCI India works to create an enabling environment for enterprises of all sizes. The Chamber actively supports key national initiatives such as Startup India, Make in India, Digital India, Atmanirbhar Bharat, Skill India, and Viksit Bharat 2047 by connecting innovative enterprises with government opportunities and promoting inclusive economic development.

CCI India operates through sector-specific councils, industry forums, knowledge platforms, and state-level engagements that address emerging opportunities and challenges across sectors including manufacturing, agriculture, technology, healthcare, education, infrastructure, sustainability, MSMEs, and startups. The Chamber regularly organizes policy dialogues, investment summits, business delegations, workshops, conferences, and knowledge-sharing initiatives to strengthen India's economic ecosystem.

With a strong commitment to innovation, entrepreneurship, and public-private collaboration, CCI India strives to empower enterprises, facilitate investment, enhance competitiveness, and contribute to India's journey toward becoming a globally competitive and economically resilient nation. Its role as a knowledge partner and industry catalyst enables ministries, departments, state governments, startups, and businesses to collaborate effectively in achieving national development objectives.

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SECTION 1: INTRODUCTION TO THE MINISTRY OF EXTERNAL AFFAIRS

1.1 Constitutional and Institutional Mandate

The Ministry of External Affairs derives its authority from Article 53(1) and Article 73 of the Constitution of India, which vest executive power of the Union in the President and extend that power to all matters on which Parliament has power to make laws including foreign affairs, foreign trade, and treaties (Entries 10–21, Union List, Seventh Schedule). The MEA is mandated to: conduct and coordinate all aspects of India's foreign policy; negotiate and implement international treaties, agreements, and conventions; represent India before the United Nations, G20, BRICS, SCO, WTO, and other multilateral bodies; manage consular services, passport issuance, and visa facilitation for Indian citizens and foreign nationals; protect the interests and welfare of Non-Resident Indians (NRIs), Persons of Indian Origin (PIOs), and Overseas Citizens of India (OCIs); and coordinate India's development partnerships through the Development Partnership Administration (DPA).

1.2 Historical Evolution and Governance Role

The roots of India's foreign policy machinery can be traced to 1783, when the East India Company established a Foreign Department. Post-Independence, the Foreign and Political Departments were merged and reconstituted as the Ministry of External Affairs and Commonwealth Relations in 1947, which was subsequently renamed the Ministry of External Affairs in 1948. The Indian Foreign Service (IFS) was established in 1946, with the first batch of officers inducted in 1948 through the Civil Services Examination a tradition that continues to this day.

A landmark institutional development occurred in 2012 when the Ministry of Overseas Indian Affairs (MOIA) was merged with the MEA, consolidating diaspora policy under a single ministry and creating a unified approach to managing India's 32 million-strong overseas community. In 2013, the Development Partnership Administration (DPA) was established as a dedicated agency within the MEA to professionalize India's overseas development assistance and project management. These structural evolutions reflect the MEA's expanding role from traditional diplomacy to a comprehensive engine of India's global strategy. (

1.3 National Significance

The MEA's significance to India's national development agenda cannot be overstated. Diplomatic effectiveness directly enables foreign direct investment inflows, which reached USD 70.95 billion in 2023-24. India's remittance receipts of USD 125 billion in 2023 the highest in the world are substantially secured through the MEA's consular network and diaspora diplomacy. Trade agreements negotiated under MEA's coordination, such as the India-UAE CEPA, the India-Australia ECTA, and ongoing FTA negotiations with the UK, EU, and Canada, represent transformative economic opportunities worth hundreds of billions of dollars.

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SECTION 2: HISTORICAL TIMELINE OF THE MINISTRY OF EXTERNAL AFFAIRS

2.1 Institutional Milestones and Policy Transformation

Year / Period	Milestone / Significance
1783	East India Company establishes Foreign Department precursor to modern Indian diplomatic machinery.
1947	Ministry of External Affairs and Commonwealth Relations constituted post-Independence; Jawaharlal Nehru becomes first External Affairs Minister.
1948	Ministry renamed Ministry of External Affairs; Indian Foreign Service (IFS) formally established; first IFS batch inducted.
1954	Panchsheel (Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence) articulated foundational doctrine for India's foreign policy for decades.
1961	India co-founds the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) at Belgrade, institutionalising strategic autonomy as a diplomatic principle.
1971	India-USSR Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation decisive strategic partnership anchoring South Asian stability.
1974	India conducts Pokhran-I nuclear test; faces international isolation MEA navigates complex diplomatic aftermath.
1991–1998	Economic liberalisation reshapes MEA's role; 'economic diplomacy' gains centrality; Look East Policy launched (1992).
1998	Pokhran-II nuclear tests; MEA manages international sanctions and undertakes sustained diplomatic outreach for global acceptance.
2000s	India-US Civil Nuclear Deal (2008) signals new era of strategic partnership; BRICS formation, SCO engagement deepens.
2012	Ministry of Overseas Indian Affairs (MOIA) merged with MEA unified diaspora governance under one ministry.
2013	Development Partnership Administration (DPA) established professionalises India's development cooperation architecture.
2014–2019	'Neighbourhood First', 'Act East', 'Link West' policies institutionalised under PM Modi's energetic diplomacy framework.
2015	International Yoga Day (June 21) approved by UN landmark soft power initiative co-sponsored by 177 countries.
2020–2021	Vaccine Maitri initiative: India supplies 65+ million COVID-19 vaccines to 95 countries apex of humanitarian diplomacy.
2023	India hosts G20 Presidency under 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam' theme; African Union joins G20 under India's leadership.
2024	India-UAE CEPA, India-Australia ECTA operational; FTA negotiations with EU, UK, Canada at advanced stages.
2025–2026	India holds BRICS Chairmanship (2026); deepens Global South leadership agenda; Operation Sindoor underscores assertive foreign policy.

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